

My Kind of Vegas

Las Vegas was loud and brash, flashy lights and cars stark around every street corner. Fashions that would have not had a place anywhere else in the world – every side of the eccentric – ran amok in Vegas and it was the ultimate scene for rash decision. Many a fur, as the tales went, had gotten hitched in a flurry of drunk mishaps, waking up the next morning with a cheap ring on their finger whether they were male, female or simply no longer sure after the events of the night. It was one of the lures of Vegas, that anything could happen and one would always come out of the city with a new story, or two, or three to share with every fur in their social circle. Everywhere a fur travelled along the concrete and tarmac, there was a bustle of noise and activity, the city never resting for even a single moment as the thrum of life grew stronger and stronger with the dark of every passing day.

And Pax hated every second of it.

Sprawled on the king sized mattress of his, thankfully, empty hotel room, the palomino equine heaved a sigh, broad chest rolling as he expelled every scrap of air from his lungs. On the other side of the wall, the clamour of his parents readying themselves for a night out with Sera, his sister back from university for the family holiday, was a pure racket. Pax groaned and rolled over on to his cream-coloured front, shoving his muzzle under the pillows. He was due to attend university in the fall like his sister. It would help a great deal if he knew what on earth he wanted to do.

The door creaked open and he flicked his white tail but otherwise paid no attention to the fur that had entered the room. They closed the door quietly behind them and waited as if for him to speak, patiently quiet for a minute that seemed to stretch into an age. Pax tensed, muscles in his bare back – for he'd forgone any clothing other than comfortable jogging bottoms for the time behind – tensing noticeably to the discerning eye. He hoped whoever had come to see him didn't catch on to that.

Go away, go away, go away, go away...

"You sure you don't want to come, bro?"

His mare sister's lilting tone was unmistakable and Pax nipped his lower lip, glancing back to his shoulder as light filtered into his dark crevice beneath the pillow. It felt safer there than in the rat race of the outside world, too quick for him to keep up with. Why couldn't they just leave him in peace? He swallowed a sigh that would have raised too many questions.

"Nah..."

It was a rather useless response but enough for Sera to understand. The mare padded lightly over to the bed, her larger hooves quiet on the thick, plush carpet, and perched on the edge, resting her paw lightly in the centre of his back. Though muscles quivered, he remained quiet and still as she stroked down his spine with hoofed fingertips, easing the tension from his body. Slowly, stroke by stroke, he relaxed into his sister's touch and pressed his muzzle into the bed, letting loose a soft nicker. She chuckled and played her fingers down to the small of his back, massaging the spot just above his tail.

Pax's tail twitched.

“You didn’t get ready in here?”

It wasn’t much of a question but it was all Pax had for her, forced to make conversation to keep up appearances when every fibre of his being screamed at him to protect his privacy. He supposed it was not an invasion of privacy if her asked questions of Sera, staving off any further questions concerning himself.

“Oh...” She teased his mane between her fingers. “Yeah, mum and I were helping each other get the zippers on our dresses up. I can’t twist to do it myself still.” She chuckled and he heard her paw rub over her muzzle. “Kind of silly really.”

Pulling his muzzle out from under the pillow, he blinked up at his sister, her familiar brown muzzle with the sleek stripe trailing down the centre. Her blue eyes smiled at him, black mane neatly oiled and coiled into braids atop her head and down the fine arch of her neck. She was more like a traditional, heavy set cob that he was, skin tight over muscle and weight she carried well. A kind fur would have called her ‘curvaceous’ but he had had many less pleasant names for her when he was a younger colt.

So it was a good thing that she gave as good as she got when it came to her little brother.

“It’s not silly,” he said. “You don’t have the flexibility to reach back. But I could have helped.”

“Why?” Her eyes brightened mischievously. “Did you want me to daub eye shadow on you too? You’d look so pretty for all the hot mares out there!”

He grunted and rolled his eyes, choosing not to rise to the bait. He had only been caught with his mother’s make-up *once* when he was very young and he didn’t think he would ever hear the end of the story. It would go on and on and on and on until it was finally told at his wedding day, or so he had been playfully threatened. He didn’t doubt that his family would pounce on the opportunity to embarrass him but he didn’t think that he would have a wedding either, not with how he was as a stallion.

Pax shook himself: no time for those thoughts. He had to keep up appearances.

Sitting up, he looked his sister up and down, momentarily blinded by the sparkles on her dress. The little red number had more sequins than fabric and he stifled a snort, clapping a paw over his muzzle a moment too late. The mare sat back, painted red lips twisting as she tilted her head to one side, her brother’s eyes too wide and innocent to be believed.

“What?”

Sera frowned, crossing her arms over her breasts and thankfully hiding her plunging bosom. It was hard to keep his eyes away from such as ostentatious display. Slowly, so as not to lose control of himself and burst into far from masculine giggles, Pax swung his legs over the edge of the bed and scooted to the side as his sister stood up and took a step back, eyes sharp as she waited on his answer. Pax swallowed. He was in for it now, if he was honest, and likely worse if he was dishonest.

“Don’t you think you want to...I don’t know...” Pax tried to be tactful. “Go for something a little less...loud?”

She wrinkled her muzzle, ears twitching.

“What are you trying to say, little brother?”

He flinched. He hated when she called him that, yet Sera insisted on too many occasions. It was better not to make a scene, even though she was only one year older than him. Sera was formidable to say the very least of her attitude. And colts were liable to become tongue tied, hoof-in-mouth disease a common problem amongst his kind. Pax swallowed hard and brushed his cream forelock out of his eyes, long lashes catching on the soft strands of hair.

“Nothing at all,” he said, eyes wide and his lips curved up into a smile, the very picture of innocence. “But you look beautiful tonight. Only the best stallion would be able to match up to you and give you what you deserve.”

Though heat flushed her cheeks, the mare slid her gaze away, arm crossing across the front of her body to rub the opposite forearm as if for something to do, a distracting motion. Embarrassment, however, did not suit her features well and a moment later the sly gleam in her eye returned, a paw on her hip as she jutted it out cockily, painted hoof-nails tapping a tune that only she could hear.

“Well, my taste leans a bit more towards felines lately.” She grinned and brought her finger to her lips in a ‘shush’ gesture, winking at her little brother. “Something about the claws... They feel fantastic when they prick into my –”

“Sera!”

Pax snorted and shot to his hooves, holding his paws up in the air as if he could not stand to hear any more. If he had been younger, he would have held his paws over his ears and mumbled nonsense so as not to be forced to hear of his sister’s exploits. Sera could be rather graphic at the best of times. He didn’t want to know what she would be like with the aroma of her first Long Island of the night on her breath.

“Don’t sound so shocked, little brother,” Sera laughed and clapped her paws together. “Maybe we’ll find you a nice lady yet. She doesn’t have to be a horse, no matter what mom and dad say. Species doesn’t matter as much as they say and the world is changing...”

Her eyes grew far away and she looked at a point over her shoulder. The mare tucked an imaginary strand of mane back behind her ear, even though her hair was done up perfectly with not a hair out of place.

“I mean...” She went on, words spilling from her lips without restraint. “What does species matter, really, when you think about it? I mean, really think about it. We’re all furs, aren’t we? We’re not like our four-legged kind, the ones that don’t have our intelligence. Silly things. Bad luck of the draw. We’re evolved. Why should it matter who we choose to spend our lives with when the curtains close?” She closed her eyes. “At the end of the day?”

Pax twitched an ear, tail flicking against the bed as he stood and stretched his arms above his head, muscles flexing. Sera's ramble was not meant for his ears, yet he let her continue anyway, working out the notion in her head. He was not the one that anyone had to worry about ending up with another fur, interest in others less than healthy for a male of his age, officially an adult, whatever that meant. The stallion touched his sister's arm, halting her in her stream of vocalised thought, and nickered, bumping his muzzle into her cheek in a chaste nuzzle. She trembled, eyes glazed over with the sheen of tears he was sure she would never admit. The stallion's jaw clenched. The cat better treat her right or there'd be hell to pay from the so called 'little brother' himself.

"Whatever you choose, it should not matter to anyone else," he said, feeling suddenly older than his years told. "And mother and father would not mind who you were with. You're the trial run, after all..." His eyes glinted with mischief. "You know. As you're the oldest. They get to make all their mistakes on you."

"Why – you!"

Sera thumped him with the back side of her paw, muzzle dropped into an 'O' of shock that could not be concealed behind shivering mirth. Swatting at her brother, she threw her paws in the air and huffed, half-turning away from the stallion with a sullen flick to her tail. For a moment, Pax almost felt bad. Almost.

"Come on, Sera," Pax said, sidling closer as if she would not notice his approach if he was sly enough. "You know I don't mean it. Stop sulking. Please? For me? For your *little brother*?"

He pouted, lips pushed out and trembling false from his muzzle, the image of a scorned colt faced with an injustice that he surely did not deserve. It didn't take much for her to come around and soon she joined him in his chuckles, bosom trembling with amusement that she no longer wanted to hold back. The tension slipped from her shoulders and Sera giggled, a lock of hair falling loose from its braid and flicking over her forehead into her eye.

"You're an idiot, you know that?"

She took the measure of him, looking her brother up and down with perfectly made-up eyes, mascara curled and spreading her lashes delightfully. The mare cocked an eyebrow, lips twisting into a half-smile that did not rise on the other side of her face as if she was trying not to let her amusement show as openly as she felt it. She blew her brother a kiss and spread her arms wide, fingers curling in to beckon him closer. He shook his head but it was already too late; she forced him into the tug.

"Still short, shorter than me" she teased, drawing him in closer to her large breasts, chin tucked on top of his head. "When are you going to hit your growth spurt, hey, little brother? Surely you're due for it by now?"

"I've already hit it," he grumbled, squirming against her as he strove to escape her iron grip. "Bloody lay off, would you?"

She took a step back, ears slanted to the sides. Her expression flickered and he caught the briefest flash of the wounded before she painted it carefully cool again, lips curved into a smile that did not reach her eyes this time.

“Well, okay then,” Sera said levelly. “I’m sorry, I didn’t mean to upset you. Just thought it was teasing.”

She rolled her shoulders back in a shrug, smile fixed and unwavering. Turning for the door, she made as if to leave without another word. The spring had vanished from her step and her brother stood with his paws held awkwardly at his sides, frozen in place for a split second of shock. He launched into action, scrabbling after her and tripping over his own hooves in his haste. He flung out his paw to her, his sister too far away already, like she’d always been.

“Wait – Sera! Please! Hold on a second!”

Pausing at the door, she half-glanced back over her shoulder, tail swishing sadly. Her lipstick smudged over her teeth as her smile faded.

“Maybe one day you won’t push us away so, little brother,” she said. “But I didn’t think a hug would be too much to ask now and not jokes that never reach the truth of us. I’m sorry I pushed you too far. I know you don’t mean it.”

It was just a hug – was that so serious? Pax gulped and shook his head, wanting to say more but not understanding the severity of the situation. Who wanted to be clamped to their sister’s breasts? He didn’t like breasts! Though she didn’t know that. He fumble for words, tongue tied into a figurative knot for all the comprehensible sounds it made. What was wrong? The stallion growled inwardly, ears flat to his skull.

“I don’t want to push you away...but...wait...Sera?”

Pax shook his head as the mare disappeared, closing the door behind her heels without another word. And, just like that, the room was once again quiet, empty but for the sound of his own breathing, harsh and jagged in his chest. Her hooves echoed down the hallway, fading into the distance as he could only suspect she reached the elevator. The stallion rubbed the back of his paw, taking account of the situation as shock melted into stomach-churning upset, sadness flooding through his body to the tips of his fingers as if he had been sucked into a pit.

The stallion scrunched up his muzzle, fighting down emotion that he didn’t want to acknowledge – *refused* to acknowledge. He was stronger than that. He was meant to be stronger. He shouldn’t feel sad. He should be running after his sister, finding out what exactly was wrong.

Should, should, should – he hated that would.

The stallion pressed his paws over his muzzle, rubbing his knuckles into the sockets of his eyes. Why were things so complicated? Was there any reason he could understand for it? He had not meant to hurt her. Yet...had no one considered his feelings?

Anger flared, licking through his veins with an old, familiar heat. The stallion's back stiffened and he curled his paws into fists, containing it as it built, second by agonising second.

Pax snapped, teeth clicking together as if he had become a feral equine, losing himself in the moment to baser instincts. What the fuck did she think he had done wrong? He'd never liked anyone clinging to him – it was annoying! He'd avoided it ever since he was young. Why did she think that was going to change? Why did anyone ever think it was going to change? Why did it matter to anyone? It was his fucking deal to deal with how he wanted to deal with it!

He stomped around the room, bringing his hooves down on the carpet with undue force, gouging out strips of material from the base layer. Kicking over the chair by the small desk, he slammed his palms into the wall, beating the same spot until the heel of his paw throbbed with pain and his breath came in heaving, crazed gasps, mane a wild mess.

Sera. It was all because of *Sera*. She picked on everything and took everything personally. He'd helped her! He'd cheered her up again! And what had she done? Thrown a hissy fit because he didn't want to cuddle up like a lovebug making gooey eyes at their other half on the sofa! He pressed his forehead against the wall, snorting moist breath over the cream, neutral paint. It was all the same, complaints and tantrums over nothing... Like all the other fucking times! Didn't she know that she already had it made? So why did she have to stick her nosy mug into his shit all the fucking time?

He wheeled about, the whites of his eyes showing as he took stock of his anger, nostrils flared as he knew he was going too far. Yet he was too far gone to turn back. The stallion snarled a curse to the empty room and launched a kick that landed in empty air, throwing him off balance and adding fuel to the fire.

Why did she get to have her whole life worked out for her? *Sera* had known for, like, forever what she'd wanted to do! Excelling in the sciences, she had always known that she wanted to work in medicine and was well on her way to becoming a doctor – one of the best, if her confidence in her exam scores was anything to be believed. And he did believe her, even if he did not want to. She was *Sera*. She was his sister. She had everything worked out.

And he didn't. Not one bit.

The stallion lifted one weary hoof after the other, making his tired path away from the wall. His tail drooped, pressed flat to his rump where bone extended out from his spine, permitting control over the wafting, white hairs.

Quietly, Pax stood in the centre of the room, chest heaving and sweat darkening patches on his golden coat. His back was sticky. He rolled his shoulders, trying to dislodge the discomfort, but only found a twinge in his chest. It was not right to go off on *Sera* so much, even in the privacy of his own mind, but too much had happened for him to make peace with her. Stuff that she had no idea about, yet chose to tackle regardless. She had to stick her nose in. She had to try to help. And then get annoyed and 'hurt' when she could not help.

Pax sighed, exhausted now that anger had left his body, muscles trembling as if pushed upon by an exterior force. He curled his paw into a fist and unclenched it slowly, watching tendons move beneath the thinner coat of hair, clipped close to the skin. Every bone in his body

ached, pain thrumming too deep for it to ever be massaged out with the gentlest touches and caresses his mind could dream up. That was why he did not touch, did not enjoy it in any way, shape or form. And yet there was no one that could understand that. He closed his eyes. Some pain was buried too far down for it to be dug up, not without due cause. He was yet to find good reason to look back.

Pax's eyes snapped open and he straightened, the natural curve returning to his spine. Standing around would do no good! At least he had not shouted at Sera, the mare having left before that tirade began. He could be proud of himself for that alone. And there was no sense in making himself feel worse, not by a god damn long shot. There was only one place that helped when he felt like this. The stallion's lips quirked, thinking of where he was in the world. And it wasn't going to be the slot machines.

Heaving a sigh, Pax opened the pale, wooden wardrobe and cast his eyes about the dim interior for his old, battered gym bag. His parents, bless them, had said it was silly to take a gym bag on holidays but, somehow, he had known he would need it. His body would not slack while he enjoyed himself, he told them, and they had shaken their heads at the "obsessions of youth", as they had said. The palomino equine licked his lips and fished out the black and yellow back, checking inside to make sure his gloves were safely tucked into the interior pocket. It wasn't obsession that drove him to the gym, breaking down his muscles every session so that the fibres could grow back again, stronger. He inhaled slowly, calming his mind. The gym was not silly and neither was it vain.

It was his safety net.

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Flat on his back on a bench positioned below a half-rack and loaded barbell, Pax huffed, panting for breath abruptly lost in the expending of energy. His black vest top clung to his cut chest, muscle swelling proudly through the thin fabric, and his paws hung down to the padded floor on either side of the bench, striving to regain his breath. He put an arch into his back, easing out the tension after completing the last repetition of his bench press, working to his last personal best if not a new one. It would have to do, at least for the time being.

Lucky this hotel has a reasonably well equipped gym, he thought as he cast his eyes around the near empty room, floor covered from wall to wall in Olympic matting. For a one-off expense, it would have set the hotel back a bit but he knew one thing above all else from his time in Las Vegas: it was a place where extravagance reigned. So it was a good thing that that lavish spending extended to the gym where he preferred to spend most of his time.

He lifted his paws to the bar above, curling them around the cool, smooth metal, two rings running around the barbell just by his little fingers, denoting the bar to weight twenty kilos as an Olympic bar. Another expected spend for a gym attached to a hotel. Pax sniffed, muzzle wrinkling up in distaste. His gloves were starting to stink again. Pax smirked at the fleeting thought of shoving them in Sera's gaping muzzle later. Again, as it would not be the first time. He could not think badly of her for too long and, besides, a brother's petty revenge could not go forgotten.

He pushed the bar up from the hooks and took the weight on his paws, arms trembling as if they would collapse under the weight of the plates slotted neatly on to either end of the bar.

Bending his elbows, he pushed his chest up from the bench, and brought it down so that the bar just grazed his chest at the lowest point of the motion. He strained, grunted, and made it rise, a push up to the top that made his breath rake through his lungs, muscles burning. It was an addictive feeling. Completing one rep, he did it again and again, forcing the bar up with the cleanest form he could muster until he had squeezed eight repetitions out of his tired body.

There was only one other in the gym and, in the middle of his set, Pax's skin tingled, sensing the eyes of another on him. Forcing himself to complete the set with a snort of hot, moist breath, he re-racked the bar and sat up slowly, head spinning from blood rushing to muscles and the effort it took to push his body to its limit and smash the line holding him back. He looked up and straight into the eyes of another equine, more heavily muscled than he. The black horse with a thick, black mane and tail blinked, startling green eyes fixed upon the younger horse. He held a dumbbell in each paw, though was not close enough for Pax to discern how heavy each of them were. His lips twisted, tugging down ever so slightly in the corner. They looked heavy. Heavier than what he would use.

Pax tried not to stare but, if the other horse was going to be so damn rude, he saw no reason to maintain his manners in the presence of a stranger. Pushing his arms out in front of his, he worked out some of the instantaneous soreness from his triceps, which had been working to support the lift as his chest did much of the work. It would look weird to rub his chest in front of another gym-goer though, so he avoided tackling the muscles that really needed attention.

The black stallion, who stood beside a long rack of dumbbells, replaced the pair that he had been using for bicep curls – a typical 'bro' exercise that Pax could not help but roll his eyes at, subtly – back on the rack.

Oh, *fuck*, he was coming over!

Playing it cool – he hadn't been given him the eye, not really, he hadn't! – Pax rubbed his bicep, wishing belatedly that he had something other than a vest top on. It was a douchey look for guys in the gym, too showy by far, but he'd thought, hey, he could get away with it on holiday. Who cared if he showed off a bit then? Now he wished he'd gone for one of his scruffy t-shirts with some manner of smirk inducing text on the front. It would have been a damn side less embarrassing.

Pax fidgeted and glanced up as the horse approached, eyes bright in an easy half-smile. The stallion swallowed covertly. How was it possible to have eyes that blue? He was probably another vain stallion who thought he was a stud and wore contacts to make the mares swoon. That thing about 'piercing blue eyes' and all that jazz. Pax snorted.

"You're looking pretty good there," the stallion offered, stopping a respectful distance away as if he did not want to crowd Pax. "Nice form."

Pax's ears perked up and he leaned forward, grabbing his water bottle with one paw. Buying some time, he took a drink from the sports top, water dribbling down his chin.

"I thought it was an unspoken rule of the gym not to interact," Pax commented dryly.

Water dripped off the fine, equine whiskers on his chin and his lips twisted into a scowl. The damn things needed trimming again and itched something awful; he much preferred to keep them neat and short. The black horse chuckled and shook his head, blue eyes sharp with an underlying, calculating edge that set the hairs on the back of Pax's neck standing up.

"I suppose so," he conceded. "But it's quiet enough and you couldn't say that this is a strict training gym."

Pax scratched his neck thoughtfully.

"It's well enough equipped for that," he offered, letting his gaze sweep the room again. "Not just filled with cardio machines. No full rack but I'm grateful for whatever I get in hotels."

"Well equipped? You think so?" The black horse's ears twitched and he half-turned away, forelock dropping over one eye. "Thanks. I'm kind of responsible for that."

Pax leaned back on one paw, uncomfortable with how the other horse towered over him and yet not comfortable enough to stand up either. He warranted that the equine would be a good head taller than him.

"How are you responsible for it?"

"I work here," he answered simply, locking his fingers together in front of his body. "Managed to get the boss up top to put in better equipment." He laughed, a full-bodied rumble. "Could you believe that they had little pink dumbbells in here before? What good are those for anyone?"

His laugh was infectious and, without conscious thought, Pax found himself chuckling in unison, tail flicking against the bench he was perched on. Taking a step to the side, the horse shifted silently to lean on the palomino's half-rack, taking the weight off his hooves if but for a moment.

"Small dumbbells aren't that bad," Pax commented once the chuckles subsided. "Good for drop sets, burnouts or things like those..." He paused, digging up the words he wanted. "Like a reverse fly? Bend over and bring your arms back. Even light weight seems to really kill when you work in pulses."

The black horse nodded in agreement, a fresh glimmer of respect in his eyes: Pax knew his stuff.

"What's your name then?" He asked.

"Pax." Pax offered his paw to shake. "Nice to meet you."

Shaking his paw in a firm grip, the stallion looked him over levelly, warmth shining deep in his eyes.

"Pax..." He repeated the name. "I'm Diego. And the pleasure is all mine."

Pax released Diego's paw awkwardly, feeling how their fingers brushed as they separated. It was strange how, for males, physical contact was restricted. Anything more than a brief one-armed hug, paw shake or slap on the shoulder, perhaps of congratulations, was reason to raise an eyebrow in quiet discomfort. For a stallion who disliked physical contact at the best of times, a paw shake was about the most he could manage without flinching away in apparent disgust, laughing and holding up his paws to brush off his retreat as a joke. He had the routine down to a 'T' for those who didn't know him as well as family.

So why was his heart beating more quickly than normal? His fingers tingled as if he had received a static shock and he curled and uncurled them to make the sensation disappear. He ran his fingers through his mane, an awkward silence falling between the two stallions, and swallowed.

Diego coughed into his paw, long forelock half-covering his muzzle. Pax wondered how on earth the stallion managed to keep it so lengthy without it winding him up every second of every waking hour.

The stallion regained his wandering attention with a swish of his tail that sent the strands swatting into the half-rack, nearly reaching Pax's knee, covered by grey jogging bottoms.

"So..." Diego grinned, ducking his head to scratch behind one ear. "I've pestered you for long enough. I'd best let you get back to your workout. If you need any help, give me a shout, all right?"

Pax nodded, something that he could not explain sending a twinge through his chest; the horse was good company, even in their short time chatting. He made Pax...relax, muscles unknotting in a sensation that was both relieving and eerily unfamiliar.

"Yeah...sure. I'll give you a shout."

With a flick of his tail, Diego turned and made his way back to the other side of the gym, pausing for a split second in the middle of his stride to check out his reflection in the mirrors that stretched the entire length of the room. Hiding his smile, Pax let his body fall back on the bench, shoulder blades absorbing the impact through the padding as he raised his paws, once again, to the bar. It was suddenly a very lonely bar, despite being loaded with the same weight plates, ever similar to the eye, that he always used. Across the gym, Diego grunted, working his way through a set. Pax snorted at the bar. Maybe the horse would come back over in some time – the gym was quiet enough to allow some conversation during a relaxed workout, after all. Chit-chat was not *that* much of a faux pas.

He narrowed his eyes and focused on the bar, taking the weight up and bringing it down to his chest so that he could no longer think of anything else or a silly horse that had exchanged a few words with him. Arms burning, Pax glared the bar down, working through the repetitions with the dedication of an equine possessed. It helped, soothing his mind, if but for a time.

When Pax came up from his final set for the bench press round, he raised an eyebrow at what the strange equine clasped in his paw. While most carried a notebook to the gym or logged exercise on their phone – one app or another – he had tucked a pack of playing cards into his pocket. Diego selected seven cards, seemingly at random, from the deck and flipped them

over simultaneously. Choosing one – for what reason, Pax could not fathom from a distance – Diego nodded his muzzle, laid it face-up on the end of another bench and selected a pair of dumbbells from the larger end of the rack. With a set of weights that would have made Pax's muscles scream and fail, the stallion took a dumbbell in each paw and hung his arms down to his sides, bringing his shoulder up in a shrug to work his shoulders. His muzzle twisted in a grimace with every repetition and Pax stifled a chuckle with a paw held over his mouth. He knew he was just as bad for making faces when doing shrugs. It was a common thing.

He sighed. He could not use that much weight though and doubted that he ever would. He just did not seem to be built for pushing and pulling heavier loads with his upper body, carrying greater strength in his legs. It was a shame when most males focused on the upper body, the chest and biceps. He wanted to match up with them too.

Maybe the stallion had something good going on with his training regime that he could share with Pax? He was older and undoubtedly more experienced, while Pax rarely had any assistance when it came to the gym. The equine simply learned as he went along, utilising all the videos online and free help from the coaches at his regular gym, unable to afford regular personal training sessions. The few sessions that he had had, however, proved to be an incredible help in correcting his inform and upping the weight plates loaded on the bar.

He shouldn't interrupt someone in the gym, he had said so himself. Diego probably didn't even want to talk to a colt who was gangly in comparison to his ripped form, only a tiny slither of bulk-gut showing through his grey t-shirt. He was in a completely different league to Pax. The stallion shook his head, standing to unload the bar while he considered the idea of requesting help, a foreign notion to his solitary mind.

With all the plates back on the rack, slotted where they belonged, Pax clapped his bare paws on his thighs, a note of decisiveness in the resounding slap. He would likely enough never see the stallion again. So where was the bloody harm, hey?

Stifling a twinge of nerves – chatter wasn't something that troubled him too much, so it was more easily done – Pax grabbed his gym bag and carted it to the other side of the gym, approaching Diego at a brisk clip of a walk. His blonde mane clung to his neck, strands soaked with sweat, and he arched his neck, petal-shaped ears pricked to the clang of metal on metal. Finishing his set, Diego dropped the weights carefully on the matted floor, flexing his fingers to work out soreness from gripping a narrow bar between heavy weights. Pax sympathised with his pain; he had the same issue with his paws getting sore when he was doing deadlifts, or other lifts where the weight rested in the curl of his fingers.

“Hey.”

Diego started, shuddering back for a fraction of a second in surprise. Pax grinned and chuckled at his surprise, nostrils trembling as his mirth melded into an equine whinny of amusement. Diego joined him, rubbing his palms, and dug out his pack of cards from the pocket of his jogging bottoms, gaze raised expectantly to the younger palomino.

“What's up?”

“Nothing much, just wondering what you’ve got there...and it’s quiet enough to be a pest today and ask.” Pax inclined his head to the cards. “Is that a workout routine? How does it work?”

“I think you’ll find that I was the one being a pest to you,” Diego said, flashing Pax a grin full of startlingly white teeth. “But this is something like...hm... How much time have you spent in Vegas? Know of *Lucky Seven*’s yet?”

“*Lucky Seven*’s?” Pax tilted his head to one side. “Yes, but that’s different. Those are curls, right? I worked them into my routine not too long ago.”

Diego bobbed his muzzle and showed Pax the cards, flipping over the red back side to reveal the detail on the face.

“I know of those but haven’t used them in a while – got rotating curls in this cycle for something a bit different. No, this is like the game.”

Pax studied the cards, each listing a different exercise with a number in the top right corner. The numbers did not seem to have any rhyme or reason to them.

“So...how exactly do you use this to work out?”

“It’s simple really. Like the game Lucky 7s, all you have to do is to draw your selection of ‘coasters’ – shuffled, of course – and flip your choices. The one with the highest difficulty rating in the top right corner is the exercise you have to complete

“Yeah, I’m here with my family, it’s supposed to be one last blowout...” He paused, combing his fingers through his mane as if to buy himself a few seconds of time. “But I’m not really into gambling when it comes down to it. Not my scene at all.”

“Seems a bit daft to bring you then. Doesn’t seem like much of a family holiday to me.”

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Packing up his bags in the hotel room the next morning, Pax’s mind wandered from his sister’s constant chatter of the night before. She said he had missed so much but, in all honesty, he couldn’t see what he had missed at all. More than ever before, he felt secure in who he was and he knew where he wanted to go and what he wanted to do with his life. He would attend university

And in his holdall bag was a business card with a certain horse’s personal mobile phone number scrawled across the back in scratchy pen. During the early hours of the morning, while Sera snored off her drink, he had cast his eyes over and over that number, unable to fathom just how he had been lucky enough to acquire it. He had not even seen the stallion slip it into the pocket of his jogging bottoms as they left the gym, a wily trickster indeed. Though it was more than impressive, in his eyes, that an equine of Diego’s size had been able to slip anything into him at all.

Pax's lips twisted as he blushed at the memories, the hot stallion pressing him down into the bed. But there was more to their liaison than that alone.

Looking out at the bright sunshine outside, Pax smiled and hauled the bag up on to his shoulder, heavy with belongings snuck into the holdall by his oh so lovely sister. She wasn't so bad after all. Sera didn't mean any harm; he knew that now. His new 'friend' had taught him that. And perhaps his family would accept him regardless of their inclinations towards stallions who loved stallions. They loved him – he knew that. He would not know unless he tried, unless he took that leap into the unknown and tackled the aftermath in his stride. The stallion would be prepared for everything and anything.

Although he would not tell his family of Diego for many more years to come, the Spanish stallion and how he stole his heart, cliché even in his warm, brown eyes, there were many more good things in life to come, experience and days to make him feel alive. The furs walking through life with him were what made it life and he shuddered at the memory of Diego's arms wrapped around him, holding him protectively close as he trembled. He yearned to feel those arms tight around him again, their muscle flexing. Diego could protect him as he could look after the stallion too. Yes, experiences were the fuel of life itself. For it was those experiences that made life worth living and Diego could not have taught him that at a better time. A few days later and it could have all been too late for a life cast away and locked up in disarray.

He was a lucky 'colt' indeed.

His smile too wide to contain, Pax opened the hotel room door and stepped out to greet the rest of his life, mobile phone clutched in his paw to dial a number that he had already memorised. With bated breath, he trotted down the corridor, ignoring the looks from the hotel cleaner as he bounded over her red plastic caddy of supplies, a yellow duster clutched in the older husky's gloved paw. It didn't matter what looks he got when all his attention was on the phone ringing, Pax's heart pounding like a runaway steam engine.

The phone stopped ringing and the stallion exhaled a breath he had not known he had been holding, slowing to a much needed halt outside the elevator. A familiar stallion nickered down the line.

"Hey."